

Ammi majus (Apiaceae) Bishop's Weed

Description Erect annual herb growing to 32 in (80 cm), with tangled leaflets and umbels of small white flowers.



Bishop's weed, like most members of the carrot family, has highly aromatic seeds.

Habitat & Cultivation Bishop's weed is native to the Mediterranean region and as far east as Iran. It is cultivated for its seeds, which are harvested in late summer.

Parts Used Seeds.

Constituents The seeds contain furanocoumarins (including bergapten), flavonoids, and tannins.

History & Folklore Bishop's weed has been grown as a medicinal plant since the Middle Ages, but has been less often used than visnaga (*A. visnaga*, p. 62).

Medicinal Actions & Uses Bishop's weed produces strongly aromatic seeds. In an infusion or as a tincture, they calm the digestive system. They are also diuretic, and, like visnaga, have been used to treat asthma and angina. Bishop's weed reputedly helps treat patchy skin pigmentation in vitiligo. It has also been used for psoriasis.

Cautions Bishop's weed increases sensitivity to sunlight and can provoke sunburn and sunlight-related allergic reactions. Side effects can include nausea, vomiting, and headaches. It is subject to legal restrictions in some countries.

Anacardium occidentale (Anacardiaceae)

Cashew

Description Evergreen tree growing to a height of 49 ft (15 m). Has large oval leaves and pink-streaked yellow flowers on long spikes. Its greenish-grey "fruit" or "apple" is in fact a thickened stem.

The true fruit hangs just below this stem and contains the nut, which is encased in red or yellow flesh.

Habitat & Cultivation This tree is native to tropical American forests and grasslands. It is now cultivated for its highly prized nuts throughout the tropics, especially in India and eastern Africa.

Parts Used Nuts, leaves, bark, root, gum.

Constituents The gum contains anacardic acid, which is bactericidal and fungicidal, and kills worms and protozoa.

History & Folklore The "apple" is made into jams, and, in Brazil, into a liquor called *cajuado*. The gum exuded by the stem wards off ants and other insects.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Though many parts of the plant are used medicinally, cashew nut is chiefly a food—after removal of its toxic lining. The nut is highly nutritious, containing 45% fat and 20% protein. The leaves are used in Indian and African herbal medicine for toothache and gum problems, and in West Africa for malaria. The bark is used in Ayurvedic medicine to detoxify snake bite. The roots are purgative. The gum is applied externally for skin conditions such as corns and fungal infection. The oil between the outer and inner shells of the nut is caustic and causes an inflammatory reaction even in small doses. In folk medicine in the tropics, the oil is used very sparingly to eliminate warts, corns, ringworm, and ulcers.

Research Research at the University of Berkeley (California) has shown anacardic acids to have significant antibacterial activity against *Helicobacter pylori*, the bacterium thought to be the main cause of stomach ulcers.

Caution The shell oil and its vapor are highly irritant—do not use in any form.

Anacyclus pyrethrum (Asteraceae)

Pellitory

Description Perennial herb growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has smooth alternate leaves and large white flowers with yellow centers.

Habitat & Cultivation Pellitory is native to the Mediterranean region as far east as the Middle East. It is cultivated in Algeria, and the root is unearthed in autumn.

Parts Used Root, essential oil.

Constituents Pellitory contains anacycline, inulin, and volatile oil.

History & Folklore The herbalist Nicholas Culpeper wrote in 1652 that pellitory "purgeth the brain of phlegmatic humours... easing pains in the head and teeth." It has been listed in the *British Pharmacopoeia* and was used in the form

of lozenges to relieve dryness of the mouth. It was also taken to help ease neuralgia and paralysis of the tongue or lips.

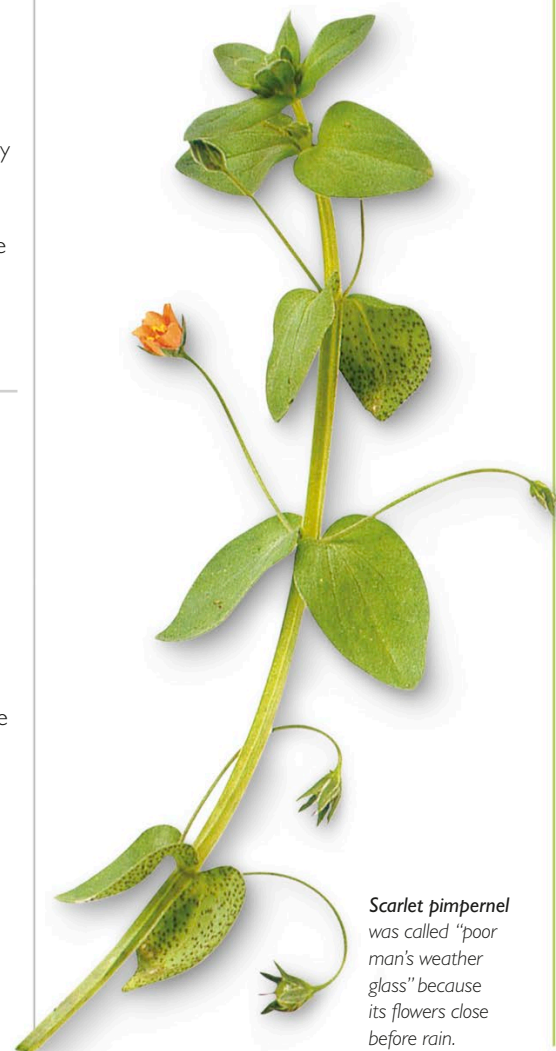
Medicinal Actions & Uses Pellitory root is taken as a decoction or chewed to relieve toothache and increase saliva production. The decoction may also be used as a gargle to soothe sore throats. In Ayurvedic medicine, pellitory root is considered tonic and is used to treat paralysis and epilepsy. Diluted pellitory essential oil is used in mouthwashes and to treat toothache.

Caution Do not take the oil internally except under professional supervision.

Anagallis arvensis (Primulaceae) Scarlet Pimpernel

Description Creeping annual growing to 2 in (5 cm) with oval- to lance-shaped leaves and salmon-red flowers on long stems.

Habitat & Cultivation Scarlet pimpernel is found in Europe and in temperate regions generally. It prefers open areas and untended sandy ground, and is gathered in summer toward the end of its flowering period.



Scarlet pimpernel was called "poor man's weather glass" because its flowers close before rain.